

DESTINATION FILE

Whitsundays

74 islands at the reef's edge — home to Whitehaven Beach and the saltwater Country of the Ngaro people.

COUNTRY

Ngaro Sea Country,
QLD

ACCESS

Fly to Proserpine (PPP)

PAX RANKING

#5 of all destinations

STATUS

Open · reef under
pressure

01 Destination overview

LOCATION & SIZE

74 islands in the heart of the Great Barrier Reef Marine Park, off the central Queensland coast. Airlie Beach is the mainland gateway; the islands range from uninhabited national park to resort islands like Hamilton. Home to Whitehaven Beach — 7km of 98% pure silica sand.

CHARACTER

One of Australia's most beautiful island groups — sailing, snorkelling and beaches at the reef's edge. Most islands are protected national park. The region combines accessible reef experiences with the iconic Whitehaven Beach, making it a high-volume destination for Orange Journeys (#5 by pax).

ACCESS

Fly to Whitsunday Coast Airport (Proserpine, PPP) or Hamilton Island Airport (HTI). Airlie Beach is the mainland hub for most cruises and transfers. Cruise Whitsundays and other operators run daily reef and island departures.

BEST SEASON

April–October (dry season) — best weather, calm seas, ideal sailing. November–May — warmer, stinger season (wear suits), occasional cyclones. The Great Barrier Reef Festival runs in Airlie Beach in early August.

GOVERNING BODIES

Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Authority

Queensland Parks & Wildlife

Whitsunday Regional Council

Tourism Whitsundays

LEGAL FRAMEWORKS

Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Act 1975

EPBC Act 1999

Marine Parks zoning plans

Whitsundays Plan of Management

02 Traditional Owners & sea Country

TRADITIONAL OWNERS

The Ngaro, Gia and Juru people are the Traditional Owners of the Whitsunday lands and seas. The Ngaro — a saltwater people — navigated these islands by canoe for thousands of years; their sites, including rock art and quarries, remain across the islands.

CULTURAL SIGNIFICANCE

The Ngaro Sea Trail links cultural sites across Hook, Whitsunday and South Molle islands. Operators increasingly acknowledge and interpret Ngaro connection to sea Country as part of responsible visitation.

PRIORITY RECOMMENDATION

Choose operators that acknowledge and interpret Ngaro sea Country. Encourage clients to walk part of the Ngaro Sea Trail or visit Nara Inlet's ancient rock art on Hook Island — among the oldest evidence of human occupation on the islands.

03 Sustainability & current status

REEF PRESSURE

The Whitsundays sit within the Great Barrier Reef Marine Park and face the same climate pressures — the reef's fifth and sixth mass bleaching events (2024-25) affected reefs across the region. Responsible operator choice directly supports reef resilience.

CYCLONE RECOVERY

The region was severely hit by Cyclone Debbie in 2017; reefs and tourism infrastructure have largely recovered, demonstrating the area's resilience. Ongoing monitoring continues across the island reefs.

POSITIVE PROGRAMS

Eco Barge Clean Seas — marine debris removal

Reef 2050 Plan

Crown-of-thorns control

Ecotourism Australia certified operators

Eye on the Reef citizen science

BEFORE YOU SELL

Prioritise Ecotourism Australia Advanced Eco Certified operators — Cruise Whitsundays holds this for several products. A portion of reef fees funds Marine Park management. Be honest with clients about reef health while emphasising the conservation economy.

04 Biodiversity & environment

WHY IT MATTERS

The Whitsundays' fringing reefs, seagrass meadows and island ecosystems support a rich web of marine and bird life — and Whitehaven's silica sand is a fragile, internationally rare feature.

KEY WILDLIFE

- Green & loggerhead turtles
- Humpback whales (Jul-Sep)
- Dugongs
- Manta rays
- Reef fish & corals
- Whitsunday hairy-nosed wombat (mainland)
- Sea eagles

SPECIES TO KNOW

Green Sea Turtle

Endangered — nests on island beaches. Keep distance; never disturb nesting turtles or tracks.

Humpback Whale

Protected — migration Jul-Sep. The Whitsundays are a key calving area. Keep 100m (300m with calves).

Dugong

Vulnerable — seagrass grazer. Reduce vessel speed in seagrass areas.

WHITEHAVEN BEACH CARE

Whitehaven's 98% pure silica sand is internationally rare and fragile. Take nothing, leave nothing. Smoking and glass are banned. Use the designated facilities — there are no bins, so all rubbish must leave with visitors.

05 Getting there sustainably

BY AIR

Whitsunday Coast Airport (Proserpine) and Hamilton Island Airport serve the region. Encourage direct routes and carbon offsetting for flights. Proserpine is the lower-cost mainland gateway; Hamilton Island flies direct for island-resort clients.

ON THE WATER

Cruise Whitsundays and other operators consolidate visitors onto larger, more efficient vessels — preferable to multiple small boats. Sailing tours (Camira, others) are inherently low-emission and a signature Whitsundays experience.

MAINLAND HUB

Airlie Beach is compact and walkable; the lagoon, marina and town are easily covered on foot. No private car is needed for most itineraries once at Airlie Beach.

CHOOSING OPERATORS

Prioritise Ecotourism Australia Advanced Eco Certified operators and those partnering with Eco Barge Clean Seas. Sailing experiences offer the lowest-emission way to see the islands.

OVERALL

Moderate — improving, with some accessible vessels and resort facilities, though many island and beach experiences involve transfers over sand or steps.

FERRIES & CRUISES

Cruise Whitsundays vessels offer accessible boarding at the Port of Airlie terminal — confirm requirements in advance. Some pontoon and reef experiences are wheelchair accessible; beach landings at Whitehaven are not.

HAMILTON ISLAND

The most accessible island base — buggies, accessible accommodation and level resort areas. A practical choice for clients with mobility needs who still want an island experience.

WHITEHAVEN BEACH

Access is by boat with a wet or soft-sand landing — not wheelchair accessible. Lookout experiences (Hill Inlet) involve a boardwalk and steps. Advise clients of this honestly when booking.

PLAN AHEAD

Confirm vessel and transfer accessibility with each operator before booking. Hamilton Island is the strongest base for clients with mobility needs.

Sources — Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Authority · Tourism Whitsundays · Queensland Parks & Wildlife Service · Cruise Whitsundays · Eco Barge Clean Seas · AIMS 2024-25.
Reviewed at least every 12 months.
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